The Future of Work and Organizations

Groups, Teams, Conflict and Negotiation

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Learning outcomes

- Explain how roles, norms, status, size, cohesion and diversity shape group behaviour.
- Diagnose team effectiveness through context, composition and processes.
- Apply the framework to the Challenger teleconference and redesign the team process.
- Distinguish core forms of conflict and use interests to approach negotiation.

Robbins & Judge (2024)

Defining Groups and Teams

- A **group** is a collection of two or more interacting individuals with a stable pattern of relationships between them who share common goals and who perceive themselves as being a group.

- A **team** is a group whose members have complementary skills and are committed to a common purpose or set of performance goals for which they hold themselves mutually accountable.

(Katzenbach & Smith, 2005; West, 2012; Robbins & Judge, 2016)

Groups vs. Teams

Groups

- Strong leader
- Individual accountability
- Organizational purpose
- Individual work products
- Random and varied skills

Teams

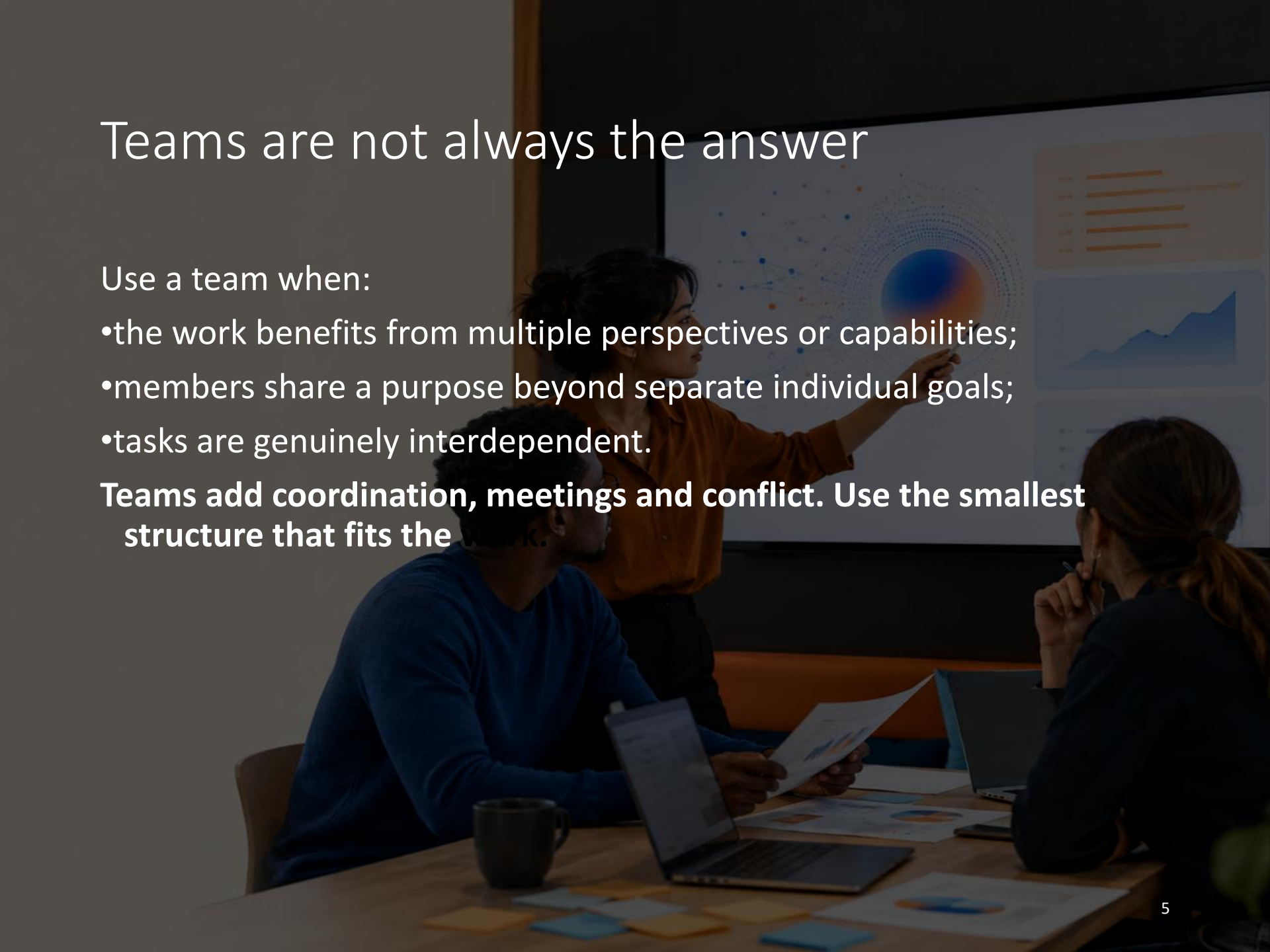
- Shared leadership
- Individual and mutual accountability
- Specific team purpose
- Collective work products
- Complementary skills

Give me 3 examples of a group and 3 of a team

Overuse of "teams"!!

(Katzenbach & Smith, 2005; West, 2012; Robbins & Judge, 2016)

Teams are not always the answer



Use a team when:

- the work benefits from multiple perspectives or capabilities;
- members share a purpose beyond separate individual goals;
- tasks are genuinely interdependent.

Teams add coordination, meetings and conflict. Use the smallest structure that fits the work.

Six properties shape behaviour

Roles — who should do what

Norms — how members are expected to behave

Status — whose voice carries weight

Size — how many people must contribute and coordinate

Cohesion — the strength of members' interpersonal bond

Diversity — how members are similar and different

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Roles create a behavioural script

Role perception: one's own view of how to act in a situation.

Role expectations: how others believe that person should act.

- Misalignment creates ambiguity, duplication, gaps and conflict.
- Clear allocation matters most when work is interdependent.
- **Role conflict**

Ask: Who provides expertise? Who integrates it? Who decides? Who challenges?

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Norms govern behaviour—often silently

- Norms: Acceptable standards of behaviour within a group that are shared by the group's members

•They may regulate effort, punctuality, disagreement, communication and quality.

•Norms vary in strength: some are lightly encouraged; others are enforced through approval, exclusion or sanction.

•Helpful norms make coordination easier. Harmful norms can normalize silence, low effort or poor practice.

Ask: What happens here when someone breaks the norm?

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Conformity with norms as a double-edged sword



WELLS FARGO

Volkswagen and BMW are fined nearly $1 billion for colluding on emissions technology.

Status shapes attention and influence

Status is a socially defined position or rank assigned to a group or member by others.

•It often follows control over resources, formal authority, expertise or visible contribution.

•High-status members tend to speak more and influence decisions.

•A team loses information when status outweighs task-relevant expertise.

Ask: Whose evidence is accepted—and whose must be repeatedly justified?

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Diagnose the meeting: roles, norms and status

A senior manager strongly endorses Option A. A junior analyst has evidence favouring Option B. The chair assumes the analyst will challenge; the analyst assumes the chair will invite dissent.

Work in pairs. Identify:

- the misaligned role perceptions and expectations
- the norm that may be forming
- how status affects whose evidence is heard

Output: one meeting-process change that addresses all three.

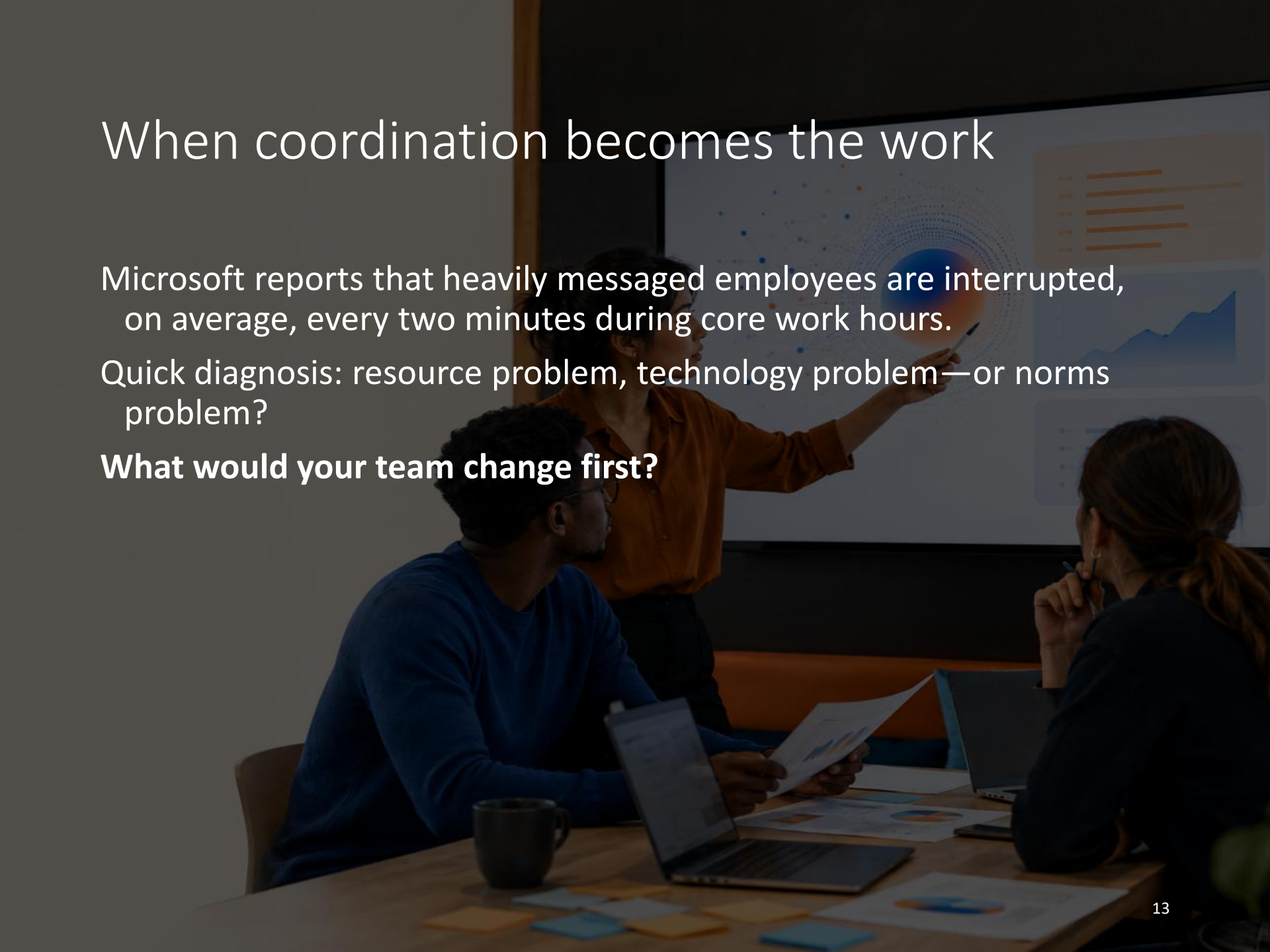
Size creates a coordination trade-off

- Larger groups can offer more knowledge, perspectives and ideas.
- They also create more communication links, coordination costs and opportunities to hide individual effort.
- Social loafing becomes more likely when individual contributions are difficult to identify.
- Smaller groups coordinate more easily but may have narrower expertise and fewer ideas.

Practical rule: use the smallest group that contains the capabilities the task requires.

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When coordination becomes the work



Microsoft reports that heavily messaged employees are interrupted, on average, every two minutes during core work hours.

Quick diagnosis: resource problem, technology problem—or norms problem?

What would your team change first?

Cohesion can strengthen effort—or conformity

Cohesion is the interpersonal bond and commitment connecting group members.

- It can support morale, persistence, coordination and mutual assistance.
- Performance gains are strongest when group norms support high performance.
- Strong cohesion with poor norms can reinforce conformity or protect weak practice.

Cohesion is not the same as liking everyone, trust, identity or team efficacy.

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Diversity creates two competing pathways

Information processing: different knowledge and perspectives can improve creativity, problem solving and decision quality.

Social categorization: visible or meaningful differences can create subgroups, lower identification and increase misunderstanding or conflict.

- Surface-level diversity concerns readily observable characteristics.
- Deep-level diversity concerns values, attitudes and perspectives.
- Functional diversity concerns expertise and occupational background.

A separate session will examine when and how the information advantage is realized.

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Diagnose a group you know

Choose a workplace, project or study group that both partners can understand.

1. Diagnose it using at least four properties: roles, norms, status, size, cohesion and diversity.
2. Identify the property with the greatest effect on behaviour.
3. Propose one realistic change—and one possible unintended consequence.

Be ready to report the diagnosis, not the whole story.

Team effectiveness has three diagnostic layers

Context: Does the wider environment enable the team?

Composition: Does the team contain and allocate the right people?

Processes: Do members convert their inputs into coordinated action?

Performance is not explained by “good people” alone. Diagnose the system around and between them.

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Context enables—or constrains—the team

- Adequate resources
- Leadership and structure
- Culture or climate
- Performance evaluation and rewards
- Technology and virtuality
- Interdependence and norms
- Crises and extreme contexts

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Composition asks whether the team is well staffed

- Abilities and teamwork skills
- Personality
- Allocation of roles
- Diversity
- Size
- Member flexibility
- Member preferences for teamwork

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Processes turn potential into performance

- Common purpose
- Motivation and aligned goals
- Team efficacy
- Conflict
- Cohesion
- Social loafing

These processes matter especially when teams are large or highly interdependent.

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BREAK • 10 MINUTES

When we return: Challenger as a context–composition–process diagnosis.



- Decision made by teleconference on the night before launch.
- High stakes, schedule pressure and incomplete, ambiguous evidence.
- Morton Thiokol engineers raised concerns about O-ring performance in cold conditions.
- Participants held different expertise, status, goals and organizational loyalties.

The exercise diagnoses the group process—not individual character.

Group decision making in the Challenger launch decision

- **Key characters:**
- Roger Boisjoly- Member of seal task force at Morton Thiokol, yellow top.
- Robert (Bob) Lund. Vice president, engineering Morton Thiokol. Red Cardigan.
- Larry Mulloy- NASA. Blue shirt.
- Joe Kilminster- Morton Thiokol, waistcoat

Watch through one diagnostic lens

- Roles and role expectations
- Norms and status
- Size, structure and technology
- Resources, culture and crisis
- Abilities, functional diversity and interdependence
- Common purpose, motivation and conflict

Record a specific moment—not a general impression.

From observation to diagnosis

- What exactly happened?
- Which concept best explains it?
- How did it affect information, participation or coordination?
- Was the problem located in context, composition, processes—or their interaction?
- What one redesign would most improve the decision process?

Support every claim with evidence from the reconstruction.

Challenger was a system of interacting problems

- Relevant expertise existed but was not effectively integrated.
- Formal status and organizational pressure shaped whose interpretation prevailed.
- A large, technology-mediated discussion lacked clear facilitation and shared evidence.
- Participants did not share the same immediate purpose or decision frame.
- Task and process disagreement became defensive and difficult to sustain.

Avoid reducing the case to personality, "groupthink" or one missing concept.

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Redesign the process, not just the people

- Name a facilitator and decision owner; clarify their different roles.
- Make relevant evidence visible to all participants.
- State the decision rule and safety threshold before debate.
- Invite technical experts first and require explicit responses to unresolved concerns.
- Use a structured pause to reconsider assumptions and alternatives.
- Record individual and joint accountability for the recommendation.

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The Effect of Being Remote on Conflict

https://www.facebook.com/HBR/videos/how-to-deal-with-remote-conflict/2785063015116474/



Conflict begins with perceived interference

Conflict begins when one party perceives that another has negatively affected—or may affect—something it cares about.

The Challenger discussion shows why effective teams must surface and manage disagreement rather than suppress it.



"Workplace conflict?"

Conflict can help or hinder performance

Functional conflict: supports group goals and improves performance.

Dysfunctional conflict: hinders group performance.

- The outcome depends on the issue, intensity, timing and how the conflict is managed.
- The goal is not “no disagreement.” It is useful disagreement without destructive escalation.

Diagnose what the disagreement is about

Task conflict: the content and goals of the work; moderate levels can help some nonroutine tasks.

Process conflict: how work, responsibility or resources should be organized; low levels may be useful.

Relationship conflict: interpersonal incompatibility, tension or animosity; usually dysfunctional.

A task disagreement can become relationship conflict when people attack competence, motives or character.

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Gwen, a nurse in a primary healthcare team, was experiencing repeated conflict with the social worker attached to her team. They tended to disagree over cases of suspected non-accidental injury to children where Gwen felt that the social worker was too ready to involve the courts and the police and too dismissive of Gwen's knowledge of the families involved.

The conflict had escalated to the extent that the two had had a heated disagreement in Gwen's office that was overheard by other members of staff. Gwen accused the social worker of being unfeeling and too autocratic. The social worker responded by telling Gwen that it was
not her job to be doing social work and that she should be looking after the physical health of the family. He called her argumentative, interfering and non-communicative and accused her of not being able to work effectively in a team.

1. **What type or types of conflict are apparent here?**
2. **What organizational factors contribute to the conflict?**
3. **How might this conflict be successfully managed by a team lead, or Gwen and the social worker in her team?**

Choose a conflict approach to fit the situation

Yield/accommodate — protect the relationship when the issue matters more to the other party.

Avoid — delay when the issue is minor, information is missing or emotions are too high.

Force/compete — act decisively when speed, safety or principle requires it.

Compromise — find a workable middle ground.

Problem-solve/collaborate — integrate interests when the issue matters to both sides.

No single approach is always best.

Negotiation improves when interests become visible

Position: what someone says they want.

Interest: the need, concern, fear or goal beneath that position.

•Separate the people from the problem.

•Ask why an outcome matters; identify shared and different interests.

•Generate options for mutual gain.

•Use objective criteria to assess solutions.



Fisher, Ury & Patton

A short negotiation application

Two employees both want to lead a visible client project.

Employee A: wants leadership experience to support promotion.

Employee B: wants to protect quality and keep delivery organized.

- What are their positions?
- What are their underlying interests?
- Propose an arrangement that creates value before dividing it.
- What objective criteria would make the arrangement credible?

Effective teams are designed and enacted

- Group properties shape what members notice, say and do.
- Context determines whether the team is enabled and appropriately structured.
- Composition determines whether relevant capability is present and allocated.
- Processes determine whether members convert that potential into collective performance.
- Conflict is inevitable; its type and management determine whether it helps or harms.

Final diagnostic: What should this team keep, stop and redesign?

References

Robbins, S. P., & Judge, T. A. (2024). Organizational Behavior (19th ed.). Pearson. Chapters 9–10.

Hackman, J. R., & Katz, N. (2010). Group behavior and performance. In The Handbook of Social Psychology (5th ed.), 1208–1251.

Yeşilbaş Özenç, Y. (2022). Group behavior: A conceptual analysis. International Journal of Excellent Leadership, 2(2), 1–9.

Koudenburg, N., & Jans, L. (2023). The group dynamics sparking social change. Frontiers in Social Psychology, 14, 1240173.

Additional conflict and Challenger sources are retained in the instructor notes.

REFERENCE MATERIAL

The following slides retain detailed examples and applications for review after class.

Quick call: whose role is it?

A hybrid team misses a client deadline.

The lead thought the analyst would chase approvals; the analyst thought the lead owned escalation.

30 seconds: role perception, role expectations—or both?

What should be made explicit next time?

What norm are you creating?

A remote teammate messages at 10:45 p.m. Nobody has discussed after-hours availability.

Vote: A. Reply now B. Reply tomorrow C. Agree a norm first

What might each response silently teach the group?

Resources, leadership and structure

Resources: timely information, equipment, staffing and organizational support.

Leadership: motivate, coordinate, structure work and help members interpret conditions.

Structure: allocate roles, distribute workload and clarify decision rights.

Ask: Is failure being attributed to the team when the organization has withheld what it needs?

Climate, rewards and technology send signals

Culture or climate: What behaviours are valued, expected and reinforced?

Evaluation and rewards: Do systems encourage individual competition, teamwork—or both?

Technology/virtuality: Can members access information, coordinate and build reliable working relationships?

•Hybrid reward systems can recognize both individual contribution and team outcomes.

•Technology expands access but can fragment attention, context and shared understanding.

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Async work is a team norm

GitLab defaults toward written, asynchronous work: document decisions, set milestones, then use meetings deliberately.

Which problem does this address—time zones, status, interruptions or shared memory?

Could the norm create a new problem?

Interdependence and crisis raise the stakes

Interdependence: The success of each member depends on others' contributions.

Norms: Shared standards tell members how to coordinate and respond under pressure.

Crisis: Time pressure and ambiguity can reveal capability—or unravel the team.

•Effective crisis teams clarify roles, share information, coordinate and adapt.

•Leaders help members make sense of conditions rather than merely demand speed.

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Expertise only helps when it is allocated well

Abilities and skills: Technical capability sets limits; communication, planning, collaboration and conflict skills help combine it.

Personality: Conscientiousness, agreeableness, openness and emotional stability can support different team demands.

Role allocation: Core responsibilities should fit members' strengths and preferences.

•Teams also need transactive memory: knowing who knows what and who is best at what.

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Composition involves practical trade-offs

Size: More capability versus greater coordination cost and loafing risk.

Member flexibility: Can people adapt roles and back one another up as work changes?

Member preferences: Requiring people who strongly prefer solo work to team can reduce morale and satisfaction.

•Select for teamwork potential—not technical talent alone.

•Training can improve communication, problem solving, negotiation and shared mental models.

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Future skills are still team skills

WEF reports rising importance for leadership and social influence, resilience and flexibility—alongside AI and big data.

One-minute pair question:

If AI performs more analysis and execution, which human team process becomes more important—not less? Why?

Purpose, motivation and efficacy reinforce effort

Common purpose: What are we collectively trying to achieve?

Motivation: Do specific, challenging goals align individual effort with team outcomes?

Team efficacy: Do we collectively believe we can succeed at the task?

- Small wins and relevant training can build efficacy.
- Effective teams reflect on and adjust their plans when conditions change.

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Conflict, cohesion and loafing affect contribution

Conflict: Task disagreement can improve nonroutine work when it remains focused and manageable.

Cohesion: Bond and commitment can support effort when norms favour performance.

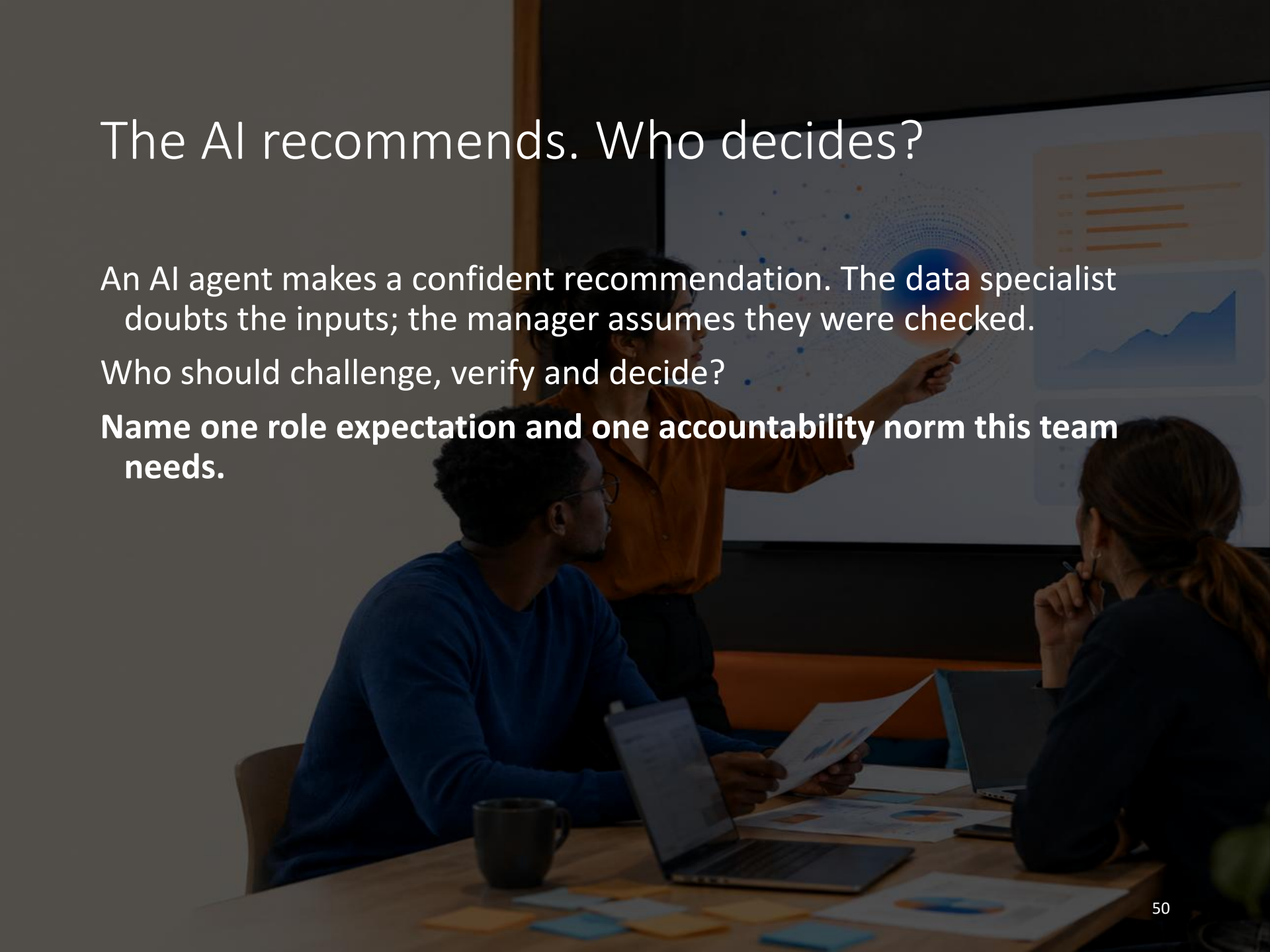
Social loafing: Members may reduce effort when their individual contribution is hard to identify.

•Make members individually and jointly accountable.

•Clarify responsibilities, make contributions visible and connect individual goals to team goals.

Robbins & Judge (2024)

The AI recommends. Who decides?



An AI agent makes a confident recommendation. The data specialist doubts the inputs; the manager assumes they were checked.

Who should challenge, verify and decide?

Name one role expectation and one accountability norm this team needs.

Future teams make coordination more explicit

- Hybrid and virtual teams need deliberate communication rhythms and accessible information.
- Fluid teams require rapid role clarification and shared expectations.
- Human–AI teams still need human accountability, challenge and integration of expertise.
- Distributed teams need stronger shared mental models: what are we doing, how and who knows what?

Technology changes the setting; it does not remove roles, norms, status or interdependence.

Robbins & Judge (2024)